

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN GABON

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is honest that Gabon has no landmark community victory to point to, that its politics are uncertain after long authoritarian rule, and that a semi-authoritarian state resists open protest. It is built around the levers that do exist here — the world's climate money and Gabon's own green promises, the national parks, the forest law, and the land rights of forest communities — and names each in plain words. Throughout, it puts your safety first.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

The situation in Gabon is unusual and, in one respect, hopeful: Gabon still has almost all of its rainforest, and is the first African country to be **paid by the world to keep it standing**. Nearly nine-tenths of the land is covered by **Congo Basin rainforest** — a forest so vast it absorbs far more carbon than the whole country emits, home to forest elephants and great apes, one of the last great intact rainforests on earth. Over three decades Gabon held its deforestation to a fraction of a percent a year, created **thirteen national parks**, and, in a landmark deal, began receiving **international payments — through the Central African Forest Initiative and the carbon framework — for the emissions its standing forest prevents**. And yet the forest is not safe: illegal logging has been rising, palm-oil plantations have cleared tens of thousands of hectares, an iron-ore mega-project threatens to fragment a forested region, and the country's dependence on oil pushes it to convert forest for new revenue.

A community in Gabon works with real, if indirect, levers, all running through the green bargain the country has struck — being paid by the world to keep its forest standing. The **climate-finance framework** (CAFI and the carbon deal) pays for real protection, and its partners can be asked to **condition the money** on genuine protection and on the rights of forest communities. Gabon's **green commitments and reputation** as a conservation leader can be held to — its great vulnerability and its great lever are the same: the gap between that green promise and any destruction that betrays it. The **thirteen national parks** and the **forest law** protect land. And forest communities hold **land and tenure rights** the money was meant to secure. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The **green image is real but incomplete** — illegal logging has risen, and palm, mining, and oil press against the trees. The **money too rarely reaches forest communities** — the climate payments have been criticised as overstated and as flowing overwhelmingly to governments and schemes rather than to the forest peoples whose land the money was meant to secure. And the **politics are uncertain** — Gabon emerged from more than half a century of one family's rule into a transition whose environmental direction is not yet set, with civil-society space constrained, so caution and safety come first. So aim for what these levers can deliver, insisting that a country paid to conserve actually protect the forest and its people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A destructive project looks unstoppable, but it collides with a green bargain the country is paid and praised for, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Gabonese fight turns on the **gap between the green promise and the destruction**; on the **climate-finance partners** who can condition their money; on the **national parks and the forest law**; and on the **land rights of forest communities**. Every one of those is a link you

can grab — and the world's climate money and Gabon's own promises run through them all. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull — safely.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you begin — and mind your safety in a constrained space — work out your real situation:

- **If destruction betrays the green promise, that gap is your sharpest lever** — a country paid and praised for its forest is vulnerable to being exposed breaking the bargain.
- **If climate finance funds the conservation, its partners are a real route** — they can be asked to condition their money on real protection and community rights.
- **If it's in or near a national park, or breaks the forest law, those protections bite** — the parks and the law are real.
- **If it takes forest communities' land, their tenure rights are the claim the money was meant to secure** — and often hasn't.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **hold Gabon to its green bargain, and ask the climate-finance partners to condition their money**, and **anchor on forest communities' land rights** — the levers a paid-to- conserve country offers. Do it carefully, safely, in a constrained space.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

The state, deeply dependent on oil and mining revenue, drives major projects — but it is bound by its **green commitments and reputation** and by the **climate-finance framework** (CAFI and the carbon deal) whose partners it depends on. The **thirteen national parks** and the **forest law** protect land, administered by the parks and forest authorities. Forest communities hold **land and tenure rights**. And the transition government's direction is unset. Know which of these you can reach — the green bargain and its financiers are the sharpest, the state the least movable.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The green promise and the destruction. *Your opening — the sharpest:* document the **gap** between the green promise and the destruction that betrays it.

The climate-finance partners. *Your opening — a real route:* ask the **CAFI and carbon partners** to condition their money on real protection and community rights.

The parks and the forest law. *Your opening:* a project in or near a **national park**, or breaching the **forest law** or certification, is vulnerable.

Community land rights. *Your opening:* the **land and tenure rights** of forest communities — the claim the money was meant to secure.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and who finances it** — the company and any international lenders, both reachable through standards and reputation. **What green promise it breaks** — because the gap between the bargain and the betrayal is your lever. **What the climate money was meant to secure** — the

forest's protection and the communities' tenure — because a failure there is a demand on the partners.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **climate-finance partners** (CAFI, the carbon framework) fund the bargain and can condition it. Gabon's **green commitments and reputation** can be held to. The **national parks and forest law** protect land. Forest communities' **land rights** are the claim. And Gabon's — and the world's — **environmental and human-rights organisations, forest-community networks, international watchdogs, and press** are the forces that reach furthest, holding a paid-to-serve country to its bargain.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises, and there is no landmark win here. What most moves them: whether the green betrayal can be documented, whether the finance partners can be reached, and how constrained the space is.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost/Risk	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Expose the green-promise gap	25–50%	months–yr	low	Reputational pressure; a rethink
Ask finance partners to condition money	30–55%	months–yr	low	Money tied to real protection/rights
Invoke the parks / forest law	25–50%	months–yr	low–risk	Project barred or curbed
Assert community land / tenure rights	25–50%	months–yr	low	Tenure secured; the money's purpose met
Certification / financier standards	25–50%	months–yr	low	A company held to its standards
International watchdogs + press	30–55%	months–yr	low	Global exposure of a betrayal
Everything together (green gap, finance, land rights)	30–55%	months–2 yr	mod	Promise honoured; forest and tenure defended
Direct confrontation with the state	5–20%	—	high risk	Often ineffective and dangerous

The levers that move the needle most are **exposing the green-promise gap** and **asking the climate-finance partners to condition their money**, backed by the **parks, the forest law, and community land rights**. There's no landmark ceiling to cite — the honest floor is an oil-dependent state, a green image that's incomplete, money that rarely reaches forest peoples, and a constrained, uncertain political space. So aim for the green promise honoured, a betrayal exposed, money conditioned on real protection and rights, a forest defended, and tenure secured.

On cost and risk: exposing the gap, reaching the finance partners, and asserting land rights are low-cost; but direct confrontation in a constrained space carries real risk. The great strength is a country paid and praised for its forest, which can be held to that bargain from the world; the great requirements are to work the green bargain and the financiers rather than confront the state, and to keep your people safe.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this broken promise, this finance condition, this forest tenure — is strong. Answer five questions in writing, carefully.

- 1. What is it, and who's behind and financing it?** Name the project (logging, palm, mining, road), the company, and any international lenders.
- 2. What forest and community does it harm?** Document the **forest cleared or fragmented, the parks or protected forest touched, the communities' land taken** — the human and ecological cost.
- 3. What green promise and money does it betray?** The conservation commitments, the CAFI and carbon deal, the certification — because **the gap between the green bargain and the destruction is your sharpest lever**.
- 4. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline?** Is an approval, assessment, or finance decision pending? Is clearing underway? These openings matter.
- 5. Is the community's tenure at stake, who's affected, and who's at risk?** The forest communities and their land rights; and — carefully, in a constrained space — organisations and watchdogs. Mind everyone's safety.

What this looks like in real life. An iron-ore or palm project fragments a forested region and takes a community's land, in a country paid to keep its forest standing. The five questions yield: the company and its financiers; the forest and community harm; the green promise and climate money it betrays (the lever); an approval or clearing in play; and a community whose tenure is at stake. That's the Gabonese pattern — expose the green-promise gap, ask the finance partners to condition their money, invoke the parks and forest law, and anchor on the community's land rights.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can hold Gabon to its bargain and one that can't is documented proof of the betrayal. Build it in three layers, carefully.

Layer one: the destruction and the community harm. Document the **forest cleared or fragmented, the parks or protected forest touched, the land taken from forest communities** — with dated, located evidence (maps, imagery where available), testimony, and the harm to tenure and livelihood.

Layer two: the green promise and the money. Get Gabon's **conservation commitments**, the **CAFI** and **carbon deal** terms, the **certification** the company claims, and identify the **gap** — how the destruction betrays the bargain the country is paid and praised for, and how the money failed to secure the forest or the communities' tenure.

Layer three: the finance and reputation map. Trace the **climate-finance partners** and the project's **financiers**, so you know whom to ask to condition the money and hold to their standards. Walking into the finance partners, the parks and forest authorities, international watchdogs, or the press with documented destruction and a documented broken promise is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The destruction and community harm** — forest cleared, parks touched, land taken, with maps, imagery, and testimony.
- **Gabon's green commitments, the CFI/carbon terms, the certification** — from the official and finance materials.
- **The gap** — how the destruction betrays the bargain, and how the money failed the forest and its people.
- **The finance and reputation map** — the climate partners and the project's financiers.
- **The community's land and tenure record** — the claim the money was meant to secure — gathered with care for safety.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a community that holds the green bargain and reaches the financiers — carefully — gives you leverage a state cannot easily block. Build in four moves, safely.

Root it in the forest community — and its land rights. Start with those whose forest and land are taken, and anchor on their **land and tenure rights** — the very thing the climate money was meant to secure.

Bring in organisations and experts — carefully. Enlist environmental and human-rights organisations, forest-community networks, and watchdogs who can document the destruction and reach the finance partners — mindful of the constrained space and everyone's safety.

Hold the green bargain and reach the financiers. The distinctive Gabonese lever: expose the **gap between the green promise and the destruction**, and ask the **CFI and carbon partners to condition their money** on real protection and community rights — the world that pays and praises Gabon for its forest.

Build to last, and put safety first. In a constrained, uncertain space, build careful roles, a secure archive, and — above all — a **safety plan** for those exposed. Avoid needless confrontation; the green-bargain and finance route is both safer and often more effective.

STEP 4: THE GREEN BARGAIN, THE FINANCIERS & LAND RIGHTS

Gabon's sharpest levers hold the country to the bargain it is paid and praised for, anchored on forest communities' land rights.

The Green-Promise Gap

The distinctive lever: document and expose the **gap between Gabon's green promise and the destruction that betrays it**. A country that has staked its reputation on being a high-forest conservation leader, and is paid for it, is vulnerable to being shown breaking the bargain — to the world, the partners, and its own image.

The Climate-Finance Partners

A real, distinctive route: ask the **CFI and carbon partners** who pay Gabon to keep its forest standing to **condition their money** on real protection and on the rights of forest communities — the very purpose the money was meant to serve and too often hasn't. This reaches the state through the finance it depends on.

The Parks, the Forest Law, and Certification

Invoke the **thirteen national parks** and the **forest law** where a project touches protected forest, and hold companies to the **certification** they claim. These are real legal and reputational constraints — used carefully in a constrained space.

Community Land Rights — the Anchor

Anchor on the **land and tenure rights of forest communities** — the claim the climate money was meant to secure. Asserting and securing tenure is both a defence of the forest and a demand that the money serve its purpose.

The Honest Limits — and Safety

Straight talk: these levers are real but indirect, the green image is incomplete, the money rarely reaches forest peoples, the space is constrained, and there's no landmark win. Direct confrontation carries real risk. So use the green-bargain, finance, parks, and land-rights levers — carefully, safely — and count the green promise honoured, a betrayal exposed, money conditioned, a forest defended, and tenure secured as real wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Destruction becomes a broken promise. Not "the project is bad" but *"a country paid and praised for keeping its forest is letting it be cleared — a betrayal of the bargain the world funds."*

The money becomes a condition. Not "the finance failed" but *"the climate partners should condition their money on real protection and on our land rights — the very purpose it was meant to serve."*

A cleared forest becomes a park or law breach. *"This touches a national park / breaches the forest law the country is celebrated for."*

Taken land becomes a tenure claim. *"This is our forest land — the tenure the climate money was meant to secure."*

Match it to the venue: the broken promise to the finance partners and the press; the money condition to CAFI and the carbon partners; the park or law breach to the authorities; the tenure to the land-rights claim and the money's purpose. Keep it careful and safe.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Gabon, international attention is the distinctive lever, because the country is paid and praised for its forest by a world that will notice a betrayal — and the climate-finance partners respond to it. International watchdogs and press make the media front reach far. But in a constrained space, care and safety come first.

Lead with the broken promise and the forest, not procedure. Not "the assessment was deficient" but "a country paid by the world to keep its forest standing is letting it be cleared, and its forest peoples lose their land." Use your strongest material: the documented destruction, the broken bargain, the community harm, and maps or imagery.

Work several audiences at once — reach the world. Careful domestic attention where safe; and above all the climate-finance partners, international watchdogs, and global press, where a green betrayal is most exposed. Make it easy: clear summaries, maps, careful testimony.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit hard-won proof. And protect people — in a constrained space, carry the fight carefully, prioritise the international and finance route over risky confrontation, and safeguard those exposed.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything; and mind your safety.

8A — Exposing the green-promise gap (to the authorities / partners).

Subject: A betrayal of Gabon's green promise — [project].

"We, the community of [place], document that [project] is [clearing/fragmenting] forest that Gabon is paid and praised to keep standing: [specifics]. We ask that the promise be honoured. [Attach evidence.]"

8B — Asking the climate-finance partners to condition the money.

Subject: Condition the forest finance on real protection and our rights — [project].

"We ask [CAFI / the carbon partners] to condition your payments to Gabon on real protection of the forest and on the land rights of forest communities, which [project] betrays: [specifics]. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — Invoking the parks / forest law (to the authorities).

Subject: Protected forest / forest law and [project].

"We report that [project] [touches a national park / breaches the forest law] at [location]: [specifics]. We ask that the protection be upheld. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — Asserting community land rights.

Subject: Our forest land and tenure — [project].

"We, the community of [place], assert our land and tenure rights over the forest [project] would take — the rights the climate money was meant to secure. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — To an environmental / human-rights organisation.

Subject: Forest and community harmed by [project] — Gabon.

"Our forest and land are threatened by [project], in a country paid to conserve. We've documented it. We ask for your help to hold the green bargain, reach the finance partners, and defend our tenure. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8F — To the company / financiers.

Subject: Breach of standards and reputational risk — [project].

"We are the community affected by [project] at [location]. It [clears protected forest / takes our land] in breach of your standards and Gabon's green commitments. This carries real reputational and legal risk. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the (international) press.

Subject: A country paid to save its forest is letting it fall — [project].

"Gabon is paid and praised for keeping its rainforest standing. Now [project] is clearing it, and our community is losing its land. We can provide documented destruction, maps, and testimony. [Contact.]"

8H — Uniting the community (carefully).

Subject: Our forest, our land — let's hold them to their promise.

"[Project] threatens our forest and land, in a country paid to keep the forest standing. Let's document the betrayal, assert our land rights, and ask the world that funds and praises Gabon to condition its money on real protection. Let's do it safely, together. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean — and safely — do these six things, in order:

1. **Document the destruction and the community harm — carefully, with dates and places.**
2. **Expose the gap between the green promise and the destruction (8A).**
3. **Ask the climate-finance partners to condition their money (8B) — a real, safer route.**
4. **Invoke the parks and forest law where they apply (8C).**
5. **Assert the community's land and tenure rights (8D).**
6. **Reach international watchdogs and press (8E/8G) — and mind your safety throughout.**

Even lean, those six hold the green bargain and reach the financiers — the Gabonese template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Gabon's field is tilted by oil dependence and a constrained space, so plan for it — and for safety.

When the state pursues revenue over the forest. Expect it — oil and mining are the revenue. Reach the climate-finance partners and the world that pays and praises Gabon, which sit beyond the state and respond to a betrayal.

When the money doesn't reach communities. It too rarely does. Make that failure your demand — ask the partners to condition the money on the forest peoples' rights it was meant to secure.

When the space is constrained. Under an uncertain transition, civil-society space is limited and confrontation is risky. Prioritise the international, finance, and land-rights routes, which are both safer and often more effective, and protect those exposed.

When there's no precedent. This is a young, hard field. Build the case on the green bargain, the financiers, and land rights, and lay down the accountability that can grow.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Gabon, after more than half a century of one family's rule, has serious concerns about the capture of forest and mining deals and of the climate money, so this matters — but tread carefully in a constrained space.

How to spot it. Climate money flowing to schemes and officials rather than forest peoples; permits against the green promise; land granted to the connected; benefits to the connected while communities lose their forest.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **climate-finance partners** can audit and condition their money. **International watchdogs** can investigate. The transition's oversight and the courts can review deals. And Gabon's — and the world's — **environmental and human-rights organisations and press** can expose a betrayal.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how the money was diverted, how the promise was broken, who benefits — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. In a constrained space, route serious evidence to the finance partners, international watchdogs, and trusted journalists rather than making risky public accusations, and protect those exposed. Pair the exposure with the green-bargain and land-rights case.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together, and safely. The documented destruction and broken promise build your case; the green-promise gap and land rights aim it; the forest community is the muscle; the finance partners, the parks and forest law, and the certification press it; international watchdogs and press expose it. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and safety comes first throughout.

Early on (weeks 1–8): document the destruction and community harm; expose the green-promise gap; map the finance partners; anchor on the community's land rights; build careful support and a safety plan.

In the thick of it (months–year+): ask the finance partners to condition the money; invoke the parks and forest law; reach international watchdogs and press.

The long haul (year+): carry the finance and reputation pressure; keep the coalition and documentation ready; hold the line for the green promise honoured, a betrayal exposed, money conditioned, a forest defended, and tenure secured — keeping your people safe.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Defending the forest in Gabon is a fight without a landmark victory to point to — but not without levers, because Gabon is paid and praised by the world for keeping its rainforest standing, and can be held to that bargain. Hold both truths. The distinctive power here is real: the gap between the green promise and any destruction that betrays it, the climate-finance partners who can be asked to condition their money on real protection and community rights, the thirteen national parks and the forest law, and the land rights of forest communities the money was meant to secure. And the constraints are real: an oil-dependent state, a green image that's incomplete, climate money that too rarely reaches forest peoples, an uncertain transition, and a constrained space with no precedent to follow.

Here's the discipline that wins what can be won — safely. Anchor on the forest communities' land and tenure rights, the very thing the climate money was meant to secure. Then hold Gabon to its bargain: document and expose the gap between the green promise and the destruction, and ask the climate-finance partners who pay and praise Gabon to condition their money on real protection and community rights. Invoke the

national parks and the forest law where a project touches protected forest, and hold companies to their certification. Enlist international watchdogs and the global press, where a green betrayal is most exposed. And above all, in a constrained space, prioritise the green-bargain, finance, and land-rights routes over risky confrontation, and keep your people safe. Count the green promise honoured, a betrayal exposed, money conditioned on real protection and rights, a forest defended, and tenure secured as real wins — insisting that a country paid to conserve actually protect the forest and its people. That is the Gabonese way — the green bargain, the financiers, and land rights together, carried safely. So can you.